

Pei, our architect du roi

It's only a coincidence, but an appropriate one, that I saw I. M. Pei's proposal for a new wing at the Museum of Fine Arts during the same week I was immersed in a book called "The Architecture of the Ecole des Beaux Arts."

This book, based on a Museum of Modern Art exhibition, published by MIT Press, tells the story of the architecture school in Paris that dominated so much European and American architecture in the 19th and early 20th centuries.

Former Ecole students designed Trinity Church, the Boston Public Library and Grand Central Station.

And the old Museum of Fine Arts is another Beaux Arts building, done by Guy Lowell in 1909.

What's so striking about I. M. Pei's new wing is how much it tells us about how our ideas of public space have changed in the interim.

The old MFA is typically Beaux-Arts in that it's symmetrical and planned around the idea of what the Ecole called procession — the dramatic movement of a person through space. Lowell's MFA was a kind of Grand March to Art.

Your promenade began when your carriage or Marmon pulled up in the Museum's forecourt, on the driveway that curves around the Indian. You'd step out, mount the broad steps, pass through the dark lobby, hand off your umbrella, and ascend the vast staircase — the light getting brighter with each step — to arrive, beneath the central skylight, at ART. (In those days, the ground floor was mainly for offices and storage.)

The march was terrific. Unfortunately, nothing else about the museum worked. Most patrons got lost in the maze of corridors and the paintings swelled or split on humid days. So this year the trustees, in possession of Federal money to install a climate control system, decided to go the whole hog and hire Pei to try to make sense of the maze.

Pei's solution is to build a new west wing and use it as a device to rationalize the whole interior pathway system of the museum. He does this by making his wing the main entrance and a vivid, unique point of reference that will keep you from getting lost.

Here will be the shop, the cafeteria, the auditorium, the gallery for special

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exhibits. Having all these in one place, next to the parking, will make it possible for the wing to function evenings as a self-contained small museum, with the older MFA locked off.

Heart of this wing is a two-story skylit gallery that links up some previously deadend corridors to create a memorable place to navigate from, a place, for once in this museum, where everything seems visible from everything else.

But this gallery reminds you of something else, too, when you compare it to the old museum. Instead of the former heavenly ascension to art, your experience now will go like this:

You park your own car, walk across a desert parking lot (double decked for more capacity) toward a huge blank wall. You penetrate this wall through a small dark door and burst, suddenly, into a spectacular three-ring circus of light, plants, space, food, shops and art.

What does this experience recall? Going to the shopping mall, of course. And indeed, Pei's drawing of the two-level gallery with its vaulted skylight is eerily reminiscent of Chestnut Hill Mall or the Galleria at Worcester. Clearly this is art for the consumer, but more than that, it's art seen as something apart from life.

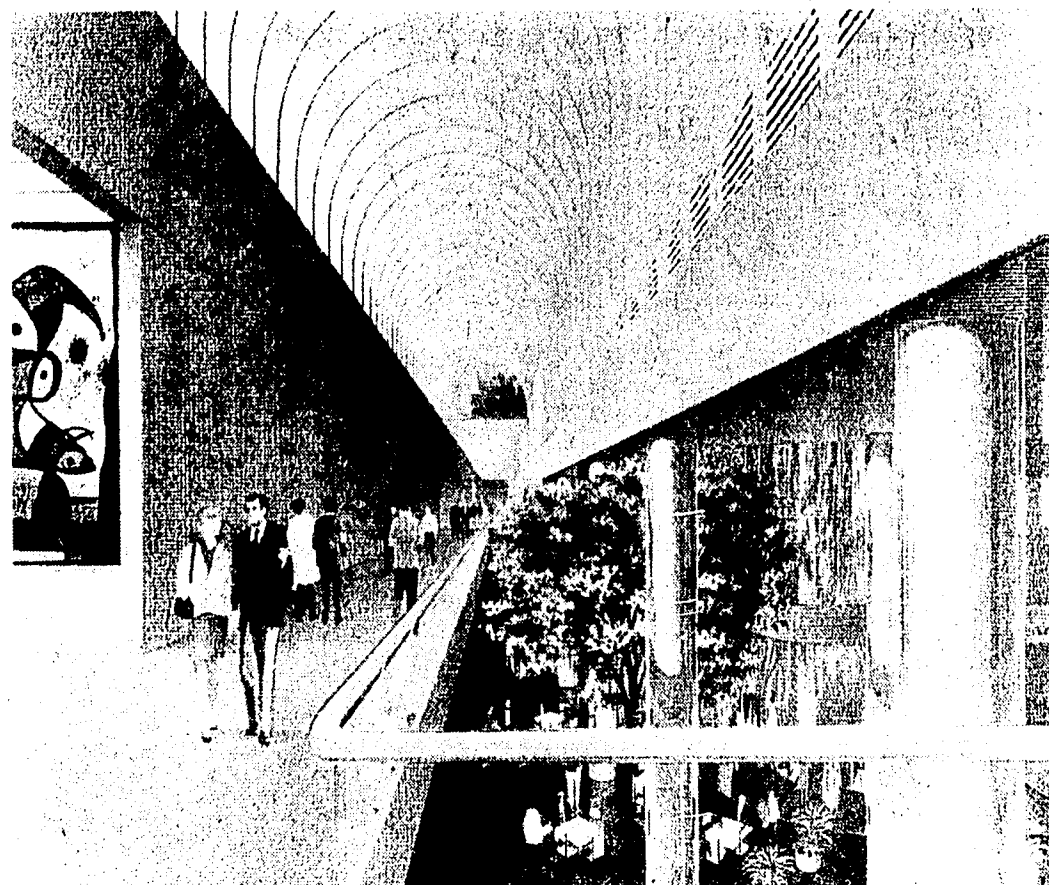
What Pei has done is create a vivid architectural embodiment of an idea of entry utterly different from Guy Lowell's. Where Lowell offered a connected, staged progression from outer city to inner sanctum, Pei offers the sudden break: Alice through the rabbit hole into an enchanted world. The blank outer wall — it will be solid granite or concrete, without visual incident — and the dark mouse hole that penetrates it are strong, honest expressions of the idea that art is another world, like the world of the movies.

By my count, the MFA addition will be the Pei firm's sixth major monument in the Boston area. Not only is Pei the most important Boston architect since Bulfinch, he has dominated the major public architecture of the city as no other recent architect has dominated an American city. His works here include the Hancock Tower, New England's biggest corporate ego trip, and the

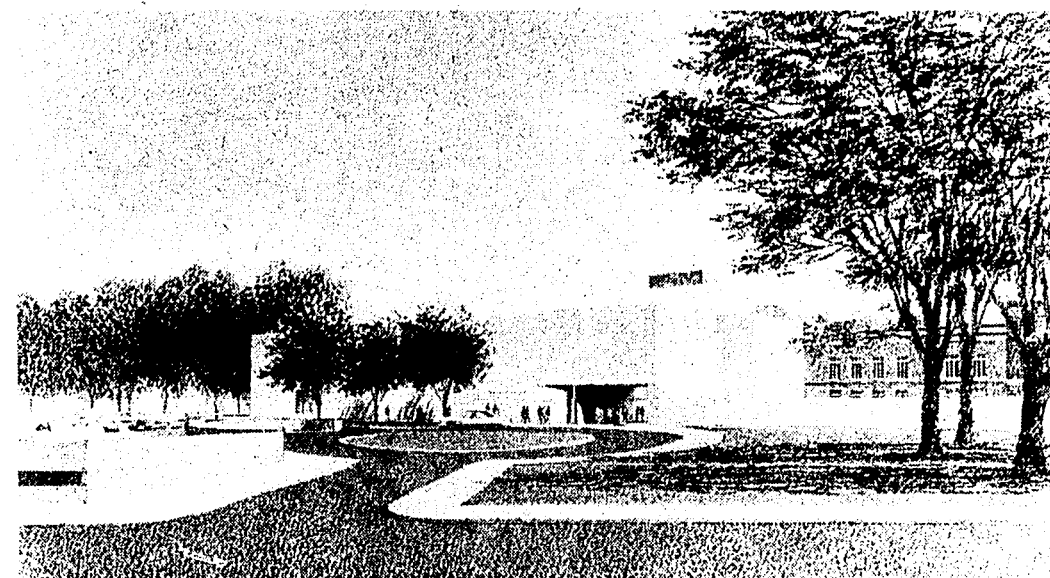
Christian Science Center, its biggest institutional ditto (both projects, unlike the MFA, were actually designed, not by Pei, but by partners in his firm). He also did the plan for Government Center and is doing the Kennedy Presidential library on Columbia Point.

For Boston, and to some extent for other cities such as Dallas and Washington, Pei has become what used to be called the "architect du roi," the king's architect, official creator of public spaces and monuments. It is surely a fate that would have surprised the young Ieoh Ming Pei growing up in Canton, China. Though Pei has Boston roots — he studied at MIT and Harvard — his peripatetic practice does raise some doubts about the rightness of a globe-hopping media star, no matter how talented, skimming off so many of the best commissions in so many cities, even cities as full of architects as Boston.

But that's a whole other issue, and certainly not Pei's fault. As for the Museum addition, you can't help but conclude that Pei's design is a superbly professional job of clarifying an impossible maze of a building. The price for that is high — pulling the face of a great building around from Huntington Avenue to its parking lot — and only seeing the building in place will tell if it was worth it.



Interior of new wing (above) is organized around a two-story gallery that connects up formerly deadend wings of the old museum. Open gallery allows views down to shop, across to cafeteria, functions as a visual reference point for visitors who now often get lost.



New west wing of the Boston Museum of Fine Arts (left), designed by I. M. Pei, creates a new main entrance to the building from the parking lot. Behind blank wall and shadowed door are cafeteria, auditorium, shop, and special exhibit space.